

MILITARY MEDALS BEFORE 1914

The 19th century saw the birth of the military medal as we know it today. Previously such recognition of notable valour was reserved largely for those of high rank. During the Napoleonic Wars, however, medals began to be awarded to both officers and other personnel. The most prestigious medals were for exceptional acts of bravery, but others were given simply for participation in an action. The medals varied from coin-like medallions to more elaborate designs incorporating national symbols and mottos. In many cases clasps were used to specify the action or battle.

▼ HANOVERIAN MEDAL FOR WATERLOO

Date 1815

Origin Hanover

Conflict Napoleonic Wars

Authorized by George, the British Prince Regent, in his position as Elector of Hanover, this medal was given to Hanoverian troops who survived the Battle of Waterloo (1815).



Head of the Prince Regent on the front

► TURKISH CRIMEA MEDAL

Date 1855

Origin Turkey

Conflict Crimean War

The Turkish Crimea Medal, "Kırmı Harbi Madalyası", was awarded by Sultan Abdulmecid I of the Ottoman Empire to all allied military personnel, including British, French, and Sardinian troops, who fought in the Crimean War (1853–56).



Clasp denotes actions in which recipient was involved



◀ WATERLOO MEDAL

Date 1815

Origin UK

Conflict Napoleonic Wars

The first award to be issued to all ranks in a specific campaign, this was also the first to be awarded to the next-of-kin of fallen soldiers.

► INDIA GENERAL SERVICE MEDAL

Date 1854

Origin UK

Conflict Indian campaigns

This medal was awarded to British and Indian servicemen from 1854 to 1895. Different ribbon clasps denoted specific battles or actions.



◀ VICTORIA CROSS

Date 1856

Origin UK

The Victoria Cross is the UK's premier award for gallantry. Originally struck from the gunmetal of captured Russian cannon, it was introduced to honour acts of exceptional valour in the Crimean War (1853–56).



Reverse depicts Britannia with a lion

▲ INDIAN MUTINY MEDAL

Date 1858

Origin UK

Conflict Indian Rebellion

Initially given to British and Indian troops who had fought the Indian rebels, this award was later extended to civilians who had played a role in the suppression of the revolt.

◀ PUNJAB MEDAL

Date 1849

Origin UK

Conflict Punjab campaign

This award was made to officers and men of the British Army and East India Company who served in the Punjab campaign of 1848–49.

